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Media Aesthetics II | Section 9

Due Jan 27th, 2023

Sherlock Sure Locks Himself Out of Social Systems

In the pilot episode, “A Study in Pink”, of the BBC’s crime and drama television series, *Sherlock*, viewers are introduced to the popular literary character, Sherlock Holmes, an unusually skilled yet socially awkward detective able to solve crimes through keen observation and deductive reasoning. In the episode, we find out the police often rely on Sherlock’s investigative prowess to solve criminal cases. Are the things that make Sherlock both a social outcast and an impressive detective one and the same? One way to analyze Sherlock’s behavior is by contrasting David Wellbery and Charles Peirce’s definitions of language. David Wellbery sees language as a bridge between the systems of consciousness and communication while Charles Pierce sees language as its own system, a system of signs. Sherlock’s nature to view language as a semiotic mechanism and interpret signs indexically, places him as a hyperactive participant in the system of consciousness, making him an abnormally skilled detective, and disconnects him from the communication system, disengaging him from social life.

The misunderstanding and confusion caused by Sherlock’s tendency to read most signs indexically illustrates how his participation in a system of consciousness hinders him from using language as a means to socially participate in systems of communication. When Sherlock and his new flatmate, Dr. Watson, are presented with a crime scene, Sherlock immediately begins to show his indexical interpretations of visual signs: the only piece of jewelry on the dead woman’s hand that was dirty was her wedding ring, signaling a lack of care for the ring and, therefore, the

woman's lack of happiness in her marriage. According to Peirce's theory, an indexical sign's signifier "is not *arbitrary* but is *directly connected* in some way... to the signified" (Chandler, 37). Sherlock's interpretation of this sign, the dirty ring, was indexical rather than symbolic because of the direct link between the physical manifestation of the sign and the meaning it pointed to. In the scene where he examines the dead woman's body, Sherlock proves to be extremely skilled at uncovering these indexical relationships, but, while his deductions are relevant and helpful to the police at the scene, the way in which he communicates the information he uncovers is ineffective. When communicating his findings to police detective Lestrade, Sherlock asserts that the woman has a suitcase and came from Cardiff, even though there was no suitcase at the crime scene and nothing on hand that would automatically suggest the woman was in Cardiff. This causes bewilderment in Lestrade; Lestrade's confusion and negation of the existence of the suitcase baffles Sherlock who quickly becomes frustrated by the fact that Lestrade doesn't understand that a case must exist according to his indexical interpretation of the woman's shoes. Sherlock and Lestrade begin to yell back and forth about the existence of the case as Sherlock storms out of the building. David Wellberry explains that, "language enables ... a structural coupling between consciousness and communication in such a way that what is inaccessible to both, namely occurrent thought for communication and communicative exchange for consciousness, can take effect" (Wellberry, 304). Not only does this portray language's power to bridge two systems together, but also that consciousness, a psychic system, and communication, a social system, are not accessible to each other without language. Sherlock is placed in a social setting, working with a police team, that requires participation in a social system, but fails to partake in social communication; he chooses to use language, not as an interface for communication, but as a tool to interpret signs solely in the system of

consciousness, thereby blocking participants in the social world from effectively interacting with him. The effects of this are shown when members of the police force label him as friendless and psychopathic to Watson; the same thing that makes Sherlock an impressive detective, his use of language as a system of signs rather than as an interface between systems, casts him as an outsider to the social system.

While Sherlock's indexical sign reading through a Peircian view of language often produces helpful information to the police, his lack of symbolic interpretation of signs further contributes to his declination of participation from the social communication system. Peirce's idea of a symbolic sign is one, "in which the signifier does not resemble the signified but which is fundamentally *arbitrary* or purely *conventional* - so that this relationship must be agreed upon and learned" (Chandler, 36). Social conventions are inherently part of the social system because of their agreed upon nature - as a collective, we create and adopt conventions to aid social interaction and communication, not personal understanding. Made evident by the observations he had been collecting on Watson throughout the day, Sherlock favors personal understanding. When Sherlock and Watson share a cab ride together, we find out that Sherlock had been indexically observing Watson the entire day, formulating a life story for Watson largely uninformed by any conversation the pair had. Watson is impressed by the accuracy of Sherlock's analysis but reveals that Sherlock was mistaken on one detail: Harry is a nickname he has given to his sister, Harriet, rather than the name of his brother. The name Harry as an indexical sign commonly points to the unabbreviated name of a man. There is nothing specific about the name Harry that would suggest it serves as a nickname or that it could be assigned to a female in Watson's family. The only way in which Sherlock would have been able to correctly interpret the gender of Harry would have been to have a social relationship with Watson, or to be

communicated the information that Watson has a sister. A nickname is arguably a convention, and therefore a symbolic sign, because it can be arbitrary and is adopted through agreement of people in a specific social system, likely Watson's family and friends in this case. Sherlock's misreading of symbolic signs as indexical indicates his resistance, intentional or not, to taking part in social systems, such as Watson's circle of friends and family. As a result, Sherlock's relationship with Watson in the episode is found to be completely transactional: when Watson asks why he is at the crime scene, Sherlock says it is to help him make a point. Sherlock uses people to inflate his ego, further demonstrating that he overwhelmingly operates in the system of his individual consciousness.

While I've discussed Peirce's semiotic theory with regard to symbolic, and, indexical signs, Peirce also believes that iconic signs exist. The physical manifestation of an iconic sign resembles the meaning of the sign (e.g. onomatopoeia). Sherlock demonstrates his ability to interpret iconic signs when he observes that the word "Rache" scratched into the floor resembled an incomplete inscription of the name "Rachel". Still, when someone suggests an alternate more obvious meaning to the inscription, Sherlock shuts it down without communicating his own interpretation, increasing police members' dislike for him and further distancing himself from the social system occurring in the scene. Ultimately, interpreting signs is not inherently anti-social or uncommunicative, but viewing language as solely an individual mechanism that serves one's psyche rather than understanding that language is a system by which individuals are connected to society, or consciousness is connected to communication, ostracizes oneself from existing as a social being.

Works Cited

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